
Like Clockwork, the Front-Runner for the Democratic Nomination Just Dropped a Memoir. I Read It. We're Doomed.

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If you're reading a Gavin Newsom memoir for pleasure, you should be first in line for an emergency MRI. His second book, [Young Man in a Hurry: A Memoir of Discovery](#), is out this week and simply cannot be read for enjoyment. It's like *Hillbilly Elegy* but for middle-class alcoholics in the Bay Area with close ties to petroleum magnates. It is an exhausting hagiography of yet another man who had an affair while in office. It is not so much a book as it is several hundred pages to *endure*.

The only way to read it, then, is as a shot across the bow for the Democratic primary. 2028 will be a big year for California: Los Angeles is hosting the Summer Olympics, and the state's governor will perhaps make a play for shifting the federal government from [demonstrably fascist](#) to [sleepily centrist](#). Newsom hasn't formally announced any intention to run for president just yet, but between [trolling Donald Trump](#) and this new memoir that frames him as a Humble Public Servant, you should expect to see a lot of him in the next two years. And don't you worry, you can tell he's going to work very hard, because his sleeves are rolled up on the sepia-toned cover!

Look, I don't want to talk about Newsom. Almost no one does! Barely even Trump, who's been publicly mocking "Newscum," as he calls him, for years. But as the Democratic Party continues to do absolutely nothing revolutionary to win any voters back, Newsom has emerged as one of the more likely candidates for the next election ([if we have one](#), *ha ha ha ha ha*). Whether any of us want him or not, he's currently the most prominent candidate openly vying for the Democratic nomination. It's not like they've had any better ideas: Kamala Harris, despite having [lost this popularity contest already](#), is gently threatening to [run again](#) in 2028. But in *Young Man in a Hurry*, you can see Newsom doing his best Joe Biden impression, still following in the same footsteps of the kind of politician that voters just don't want anymore. He's obeying an old playbook, a pre-COVID, pre-Oct. 7, pre-ICE raids United States, where being a friendly and folksy version of neoliberalism was *just* enough to win.

The book is political-memoir bingo, mostly about his youth, his parents, and his childhood dyslexia, which made reading and speaking a challenge for him (an easy proxy for Biden's stuttering). His single mother is a saint who raised him and his sister despite financial and emotional hardships. He describes his father, William Newsom III, as having a distant and "episodic" presence in his life after his parents divorced. Newsom III was an appeals court judge in California, as well as a close friend and adviser to oil nepo baby Gordon Getty. Newsom is eventually taken under Getty's wing, where he's introduced into a new echelon of society and politics. Newsom predictably [didn't mention the millions](#) that the Gettys have since contributed to his campaigns. By framing their relationship in his childhood, it makes it seem quaint, like he's not another politician working closely with a billionaire, but just a boy frolicking in someone else's garden.

The wealth amassed by the Gettys and those like them, Newsom argues, is of a "different sort from Trump's grift." Isn't this the trouble with a candidate like Newsom, who believes that grotesque wealth is acceptable among Democrats, another false sense of superiority from the losing party? He spends page after page recounting his fight for gay marriage as the mayor of San Francisco in 2004, but he's not going to get the applause he seems to want. Whatever Newsom is able to brag about in his book—giving marriage licenses to queer people or bravely announcing that being racist

against Chinese people is *bad*—is still the very least a politician could do for progressive voters. He'll always be loathed by Republicans, and amid this version of his liberalism, he'll be woefully insufficient for most left-of-center voters.

Who is this book for, exactly? Newsomheads eager to report that in 2030, President Newsom made sure that Immigration and Customs Enforcement reached gender parity? Memoir fanatics eager to hear about Newsom's uncle "unsheathing the membrane" of a condom "inch by inch over a banana" to teach him about sex? His four children? They'll be thrilled to learn important details from their father's lore: He worked a lot, and he regrets leaving diaper changes almost entirely to his wife.

There are women in the book, like his mother and his partners, who Newsom uses only to juice his own narrative. When he tells stories he's too young to remember, his sister enters the story to offer detail and, of course, remind us of how *good* her big brother is. Even when he discusses the affair he had with his chief of staff's wife in 2005, his sister is present at his press conference, taking the role of long-beleaguered wife standing by her man. The mere mention of the affair is, maybe, some attempt at proving Newsom is capable of holding himself accountable for the well-trod failures of a straight white man. Instead, it's an unforced error; if you forgot about this mostly forgotten affair, well, he's here to remind you that he was an idiot in one specific way at least once.

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Newsom is so unsympathetic in his own book that you could leave with a renewed sense of pity for Kimberly Guilfoyle, his wife from 2001 to 2006 and Donald Trump Jr.'s ex-fiancée. He quotes his sister, who lobs some insults at her ("over-the-top," "overdone," "her need for love and attention could not be met") before recounting a story about his mother scolding Guilfoyle on her deathbed before their eventual divorce. Later, when she begins the conservative bent that would eventually land her on Fox News and then (briefly) in Don Jr.'s heart, he takes another jab. "Her father, Anthony, must have wondered what had gotten into this girl," he writes about [Anthony Guilfoyle](#), his former political adviser. "He became one of my staunchest supporters and schooled me on whom I could trust and whom I could never turn my back on." I'm not eager to feel sorry for Guilfoyle, a screaming set of hubcap lashes in the parking lot of the [Republican National Convention](#), but to

have your ex-husband publicly posit about your dead father's opinion of you is a sucker punch. At least she'll always have the knowledge that up until his next marriage, Newsom kept dating women [in her exact font](#).

Trump is mentioned sparingly, and sometimes only in absentia. (Newsom recounts a childhood nickname lobbed at him while he was riding his yellow Schwinn around on his paper route: *Newsom*. Good to know the president is about as clever as a 13-year-old in the late '70s.) Trump doesn't show up in earnest until the end of the book, where Newsom waxes poetic about his power the way you might talk about someone you were once in love with. "He is an American manifestation, the peddler at our door," he says. "The more he stretches the truth in the name of the sale, the more desperate he becomes. Once inside our living room, however, he is far more malignant than any of that."

Newsom has been watching Trump scramble our political consciousness from a front-row seat. He's spent the last few months acting as his primary antagonist, using his same language and temperament to make fun of him, all while promising Californians something better. Now, he's making a renewed effort on a national scale, again promising that he understands something special about the American public that no other elected official does. And with all the knowledge of 23 years as a public servant, all that experience, and all that arrogance about having the answers, the best assessment he can come up with about Trump is that he's a tacky but dangerous salesperson? Anyone could have written that down on a cocktail napkin for free in 2009! This book is \$40!!!!

Newsom is largely a career politician, so what can you learn from his pabulum? His entire life has been about winning a campaign, and to his credit, he's been successful. No wonder he's been [walking back](#) his criticisms about Israel lately, or making room for [new oil wells](#) in California. But he remains a politician staunchly rooted in the mid-aughts, when all 7,000 of his teeth could really clinch an election. "As the calamities have piled one on top of the other and challenged the very notion of governance, I cannot help but consider what remnant of state, what remnant of nation, I will pass down to my four children," he writes at the beginning of *Young Man in a Hurry*. "If I were merely the governor of California, I might let the darkness sink deeper inside me. But I am a husband and father who doesn't want the convulsions of nature and politics to be all that his children remember of this time." How lucky to think that your job—which dictates the futures of millions of people in the state, and maybe eventually the country—is secondary to being a dad. That kind of wholesome aphorism might've played 20 years ago when it mattered that the president had a nice wife and enjoyed spending time with his children. Now, it barely matters that the president was alleged to have been spending time with [other people's children](#).

If you don't have time to read Newsom's book, don't worry: You'll be hearing stories from it for the next few years if he does indeed launch a formal campaign. As he's been doing on his book tour, you'll hear him talk about how he overcame his dyslexia, how he sought out therapy for his drinking, how his wife showed him the beauty of fidelity. It's an old but successful script. But the week Newsom released his memoir, Trump delivered a [sprawling, often inaccurate, typically hostile State of the Union address](#). We still don't know what kind of candidate Newsom might face in 2028, be it Trump (yikes) or merely an acolyte of his form of iniquity politics. Whoever it is won't be someone interested in pretending it's still 2008, or 2012, or even 2018. Newsom is determined to live in the past, but nostalgia has never kept us safe.

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